

'A tightrope walk on a volcano'

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Presented by Altana By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with MAX GRIERA GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in. In today's Playbook: — Inside France's push for n

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

- Inside France's push for new "Made in Europe" requirements in the EU budget.
- How the European Parliament is looking to wean itself off foreign tech.
- Faces in the crowd: Elisabeth Thand Ringqvist, Ursula von der Leyen, Iratxe García, Dirk Gotink, Barry Andrews, Pedro Lopez de Pablo, Alisher Usmanov, Philippe Légise-Costa, Christel Schaldemose, Wang Wentao and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick analyze why NATO still hasn't triggered Article 5 in response to Russia's provocative drone attacks near EU territory.

****A message from Altana:** Altana is the AI network where businesses, logistics providers, and governments are rearchitecting global trade. With Altana, businesses can prove compliance before goods ship and build more efficient, resilient, and secure supply chains. Logistics providers can automate the full brokerage workflow, and governments can promote economic security, manage borders, and enable the flow of trusted trade.**

DRIVING THE DAY

HOW TO MAKE FRIENDS AND INFLUENCE PEOPLE (IN PARLIAMENT): Ursula von der Leyen will walk a razor's edge in her State of the Union speech, balancing tough talk on migration and pledges to maintain green rules as she tries to hold her fragile European Parliament coalition together, lawmakers and officials told Playbook and Max Griera.

Or as Bernd Lange, chair of the Parliament's International Trade Committee, put it : "This year's speech will be a tightrope walk on a volcano."

Parliament matters: The Commission president relies on a delicate entente between the center-right and center-left power blocs to pass legislation and stay in power. That coalition has shown signs of strain lately — and critics on either side of the hemicycle will be scrutinizing her speech for signs of betrayal.

The stakes: An angry center-left camp could yank support if von der Leyen reneges on commitments to green rules or fails to take a stand against working with the far-right, Socialists and Democrats group leader Iratxe García warned in a letter ahead of the speech.

"You can use your address to tell us unequivocally where you stand," García wrote, referring to deals between centrist and far-right parties. "The time to choose is now."

Meanwhile, European People's Party lawmakers have drawn red lines on the need for further deregulation, strong measures against migration crises (like the one that hit Spain's Ceuta exclave), and even a stance that favors AI development over further regulation.

AI rears its head: Referring to recent calls from industry chiefs to slow AI development, Dutch EPP lawmaker Dirk Gotink said: "I expect quite some attention [in the speech] to AI and the slowdown: Yes or No?" He added: "If you want to slow down, then move those companies to Europe."

It's hard to please everyone. Von der Leyen may seek to strengthen her coalition by tossing out a few wins to each camp.

What to look out for: Her gesture to the left could take the form of a commitment to propose suspending trade with illegal Israeli settlements, following a petition organized by Irish lawmaker Barry Andrews (backed by 114 MEPs at the time of writing) and bilateral moves by several EU countries.

For the EPP, the key things could be proposals to beef up EU border agency Frontex, offer capitals new legal tools to deal with Ceuta-style migration crises and double down on AI development.

A resolution on the Ceuta crisis, to be voted on later this week, will be a test of whether the EPP and S&D are able to make peace after months of acrimony, Max reports. The EPP recently bypassed the center-left by joining forces with far-right parties to pass the bloc's Return Regulation.

This time, there are signs the EPP wants to make friends. "We are going to work with the other groups to try to join a text because I think the text shouldn't focus on who was to blame," EPP spokesperson Pedro Lopez de Pablo said.

The bottom line: Von der Leyen has faced bigger challenges in Parliament, like last year when she shrugged off a series of failed censure motions. But the current threat to her support base is more insidious: increasing cooperation between centrists and the far-right. It may prove harder to extinguish.

GO DEEPER: Seb Starcevic lays out the main policy priorities von der Leyen will cover in her State of the Union, from climate-proofing Europe to catching up with China and the U.S. on artificial intelligence.

VON DER LEYEN U-TURNS ON CARNEY: The Commission president will attend Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney's address to the European Parliament in Strasbourg on Thursday — reversing an earlier decision to skip the speech, Max reports .

The U-turn comes after Commission chief spokesperson Paula Pinho told POLITICO on Monday morning that von der Leyen would miss the address because of “prior commitments” in Brussels that day, including the presentation of a new child online safety law.

Speaking of which ... The Commission’s proposed EU KIDS Act will restrict minors’ access to social media and video-sharing platforms before the age of 15 and require products to be safe by design, Pieter Haeck and Eliza Gkritsi report .

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you want Ursula von der Leyen to mention in her State of the Union speech. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BIG AND BREAKING

BALTIC BREACH: NATO fighter jets shot down a drone that entered Lithuanian airspace late last night, likely from Belarus, the BBC reports .

FRUSTRATION AT THE FRENCH: EU diplomats were surprised and angry that France moved to lift sanctions against Uzbek-Russian businessman Alisher Usmanov, with one suggesting Paris had acted as part of a deal to secure the liberation of a French prisoner in Azerbaijan. Ambassadors will meet to discuss Russian sanctions again in a week, Koen Verhelst, Gabriel Gavin and yours truly report.

TRADE TALKS: European Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič will hold a videoconference with his Chinese counterpart Wang Wentao on Thursday, Camille Gijs reports .

TRUCE TESTED: Volodymyr Zelenskyy poured cold water on Donald Trump’s claim that Ukraine and Russia have agreed to stop striking each other’s energy infrastructure, saying Kyiv isn’t confident Moscow would abide by such a truce, Veronika Melkozerova reports .

Meanwhile: Russia is upgrading its attack drones by powering them with fast turbojet engines , making them much more difficult to intercept and forcing Ukraine to develop technology to knock them down, Veronika writes.

BUDGET BATTLES

EUROPE FIRST: France has opened a new front in negotiations on the bloc’s next seven-year budget by pushing for stronger “Made in Europe” rules for defense companies, two EU diplomats with knowledge of discussions told Gregorio Sorgi.

EU capitals are split over the size of the proposed budget and new EU-wide taxes to fund almost €2 trillion in spending. The EU’s 27 ambassadors will indicate where they want to save money during a meeting on Wednesday, with the Irish Council presidency — which is steering the budget talks — signaling that Eurocrat staff numbers will likely face the chop .

Officials were taken aback when France’s ambassador to the EU, Philippe L glise-Costa, pushed during a meeting of envoys last week to make it tougher for non-EU companies to gain access to Brussels’ defense and space funding, worth around €106 billion. “We have made clear that a defense fund in the EU budget without a European preference would have no added value,” a French official wrote in a

statement to POLITICO. “That is what we will continue to demonstrate in the coming weeks.”

France has traditionally backed a stronger preference for EU companies to reduce the bloc’s military dependence on the U.S., and French MEPs proposed tougher rules during budget negotiations in the Parliament. L glise-Costa’s intervention signaled that this “is no longer a Parliament problem, it is also a Council problem,” said one of the diplomats.

Message to Berlin: The French move comes amid major disagreements with Germany, which opposes stricter EU preference criteria in defense. Berlin is lukewarm about new EU taxes, known as own resources, and supports cutting farmers’ subsidies — two points of tension with Paris.

France harbors misgivings about allowing non-EU countries to participate in defense programs as a last resort. As a workaround, L glise-Costa suggested applying tougher budget rules that were introduced in the European Defence Industry Programme (EDIP), said one of the diplomats. Under the EDIP, defense projects are required to source at least 65 percent of their components from the EU.

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20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Union’s cyber agency, ENISA, announced that it has launched a single platform for companies to report software flaws. That’s part of the EU’s Cyber Resilience Act ... but what is that? It’s a law that requires makers of digital products to report certain software flaws to authorities within 24 hours. The new platform allows manufacturers to report just once instead of to multiple national agencies.

SOVEREIGN SWITCH

SWEEPING TECH AUDIT: The European Parliament’s leadership on Monday evening discussed a sweeping internal audit of the technology it uses, with an eye to “gradually diminishing reliance” on foreign tech providers and replacing them with more “sovereign” alternatives, according to an internal document seen by POLITICO. The document says the reason for the review is the “intensifying technological competition between global powers” — a reference to souring EU-U.S. relations, Max Grier reports.

European path: The Parliament’s top administrative body held its first discussion of a draft plan by Secretary-General Alessandro Chiochetti to reduce reliance on technology owned by non-EU companies. No final decision on the plan was taken. It follows Parliament’s switch from Google to Qwant as its default search engine and restrictions on some AI features on MEPs’ tablets.

The draft timeline, seen by POLITICO, calls for “a detailed assessment of digital sovereignty risks” facing the Parliament and their potential impact by the end of this fall. It calls for the administration to seek open-source or European alternatives, citing risks of a “switch off” of the tech the Parliament relies upon in episodes of “geopolitical tensions” or cyberattacks.

On the target list: By the end of the year, the Parliament plans to include sovereignty requirements in IT public tenders, and to assess (and in some cases deploy) permanent or fallback “sovereign” alternatives

across its tech infrastructure. That includes its cybersecurity and anti-malware software; its printing hardware and software; its AI models; its cloud infrastructure, including that provided by Amazon, Microsoft and IBM (American); its identity and access management, including that provided by Microsoft (American); and its corporate devices.

By the end of March, it also plans to implement European fallback videoconferencing and internal chat tools, currently provided by Cisco's Webex and Jabber (American).

Top secret: Two lawmakers who deal with the issue declined to give further details when POLITICO attempted to speak to them after the behind-closed-doors meeting. "It's about sensitive business decisions, including money and tenders," Vice President Martin Hojsik said. But he added that "we need to be certain on our own, we cannot be in a position where outside players, outside of Europe, that are threatening us, can just turn off the switch." Vice President Christel Schaldemose said "no decisions were made," but that everyone wants "to protect the EU and the Parliament."

DASHBOARD

Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union may not be followed by many of the bloc's 452 million citizens, even if it is a highlight for the Brussels bubble. But that doesn't mean citizens don't think the bloc matters. In a June poll, carried out by Public First for POLITICO, about half of respondents in Germany, France and Spain said that the European Union has more influence over the future of their country than their own government, Hanne Cokelaere writes.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

STOCKHOLM'S NEW POWER BROKER: Sweden's deadlocked election result has turned rookie leader Elisabeth Thand Ringqvist — whose centrist party holds just enough seats to clinch a coalition — into an overnight kingmaker , Tim Ross reports.

FRENCH CONNECTION: Mark Carney will cap his week-long effort to pull Canada closer to Europe by meeting Emmanuel Macron in the tiny French territory of Saint-Pierre and Miquelon , near Newfoundland, on Sunday.

DOMINO EFFECT: Democratic backsliding in Washington is increasing the risk of conflict worldwide, per a report from the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance .

ONLY BAD CHOICES: Yemen's Houthis are stepping up attacks on Saudi Arabia , further squeezing world energy markets — and narrowing the Trump administration's options in the Middle East.

WEDDING REVEAL: Donald Trump Jr.'s new wife, Bettina, confirmed on Instagram that their wedding celebration in May was partially funded by a businessman with ties to Vladimir Putin, the Associated Press reports .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny. High 28C.

FIVE-FIGURE REWARD: The owner of a vintage Mercedes-Benz that was stolen on Chaussée Saint-Pierre — just a stone's throw from the Schuman Roundabout — is offering a hefty €10,000 reward to anyone with information on its whereabouts.

NOT AVERSE TO A VERSE: Poetik Bazar, Brussels' poetry market and festival, returns this Friday to the Les Halles de Schaerbeek theater. Expect books, anthologies, magazines and live performances in French and Dutch.

A LONG KNIGHT: Also kicking off Friday is the Medieval Festival of Forest, which returns after a year off with authentic old-timey food, sword fighting, wandering musicians and costumes. It's free to attend. Details here .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz will celebrate the legacy of Konrad Adenauer at an event this evening, 77 years after Adenauer first became chancellor — but questions about Merz's own future aren't going away.

Paris: Edouard Philippe's rivals are using AI-generated memes to tar him as lazy, while his team prepares to unveil a politically risky pension reform.

London: MPs from across the house are pushing the government to confront the threat posed by runaway AI.

Washington: Democrats are pressing 2028 presidential hopeful Andy Beshear to invest in Texas — a test of whether the party can win back Latino voters.

Ottawa: Mark Carney has recruited a Conservative closer to help sell Canada to the world: former Prime Minister Stephen Harper.

Canberra: One Nation's bid to seize the agenda with a hard-line migration plan was overshadowed by the fallout from leader Pauline Hanson's comments about Indigenous Australians.

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen chairs the College of Commissioners meeting in Strasbourg.

— European Council President António Costa continues his "Tour des Capitales," meeting Austrian Chancellor Christian Stocker in Vienna (press conference at 11 a.m.), Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni in Rome and French President Emmanuel Macron in Paris.

— The European Parliament plenary continues in Strasbourg.

— Press conference on the findings and recommendations of the Special Committee on the European Democracy Shield, with European Parliament President Roberta Metsola, committee Chair Nathalie Loiseau and rapporteur Tomas Tobé at 1:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in the plenary debate on defense at 5:15 p.m. Watch live .

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen participates in the G20 ministerial meeting on energy in Houston, Texas.

— Informal meeting of ministers responsible for cohesion policy in Dublin, with Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participating. Press conference at 3:15 p.m. Watch live .

— Agriculture and Food Commissioner Christophe Hansen exchanges views with members of the European Parliament Animal Welfare Intergroup in Strasbourg.

— German Defense Minister Boris Pistorius meets U.S. Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth in Washington, D.C.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Stefan Berger; former MEP Mislav Kolakušić; Member of the Scottish Parliament and former MEP Alyn Smith; Member of the Court of Auditors Petri Sarvamaa; Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico; Turkish Ambassador to the EU Yaprak Balkan.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Altana: The rules of global trade have changed. Tariffs are tools of statecraft. Supply chains are leverage. And the old frameworks — built for a world of open markets and stable alliances — no longer hold. Policymakers need a new architecture. One that enables enforcement and trade simultaneously. One that lets governments collaborate across borders without compromising what's sovereign. Altana is that architecture. Our AI-powered network maps supply chains to the product level, verifying origin, process, and compliance before goods ever ship. Government agencies across the UK, US, Australia, and Singapore already connect through Altana to design and enforce trade and economic security policy — while businesses manage trusted trade on the same shared platform. The next era of trade won't be won by those who build the highest walls. It will be won by those who build the deepest trust. Visit altana.ai to learn how Altana can support your trade and economic security objectives .****

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